we've got out there, the actual game approaching providing a sort of relief from the storm, we line up for the anthems, staring back at the pavilion. Up there, by the bell, are my whole family, looking back. Ruby and Lola take the bell, an arm each on it, rattling it with overawed faces, huge smiles, ringing that thing as hard as they can. That's the first time I feel it behind my eyes, the swell of emotion meeting the outside, the overwhelming feeling of all these things in my life colliding at once to signify an end.

Suck it in, I tell myself, and allow this to happen; it is magical to experience this. Not many will. Once upon a time I dreamed of being this person. Be him one more time before he has to go. Chris Woakes gives me a hug as it calms and as I reach the end of my run-up, waiting to bowl my first ball. I flash back for a moment to my debut, at this very same mark, on this same patch of grass. Then, I trembled with nerves, questioning whether I belonged. Here, I just breathe in, let go, remind myself what ball I'm going to bowl and set off.

I don't know if I'm just trying to make sense of it for myself, or if there is some kind of transition happening as I run through the quicksand of the first innings of the first Test, but I bowl well for not much reward and stand in the field, collar up, hands behind my back, while debutant Gus Atkinson rips through the West Indies with record figures on a debut, finishing with figures of 12–5–45–7. He has a photo of us together when he is young and tells Sky later how surreal it felt for him to be standing next to me, watching me bowl.

For the first time in months, my nervous system registers it all. The months of waiting – the meeting in that public bar, the scurried messages overlooking that car park. It feels like, as much as the decades of bowling, they have loaded some sort of heaviness in me now too. I can feel the body catching up with me. I am running in as fast as I can, unleashing with what feels like the same venom and whip and intent as my prodigal years, only to look up and see the speed gun read just 79 mph. My ankle's as sore as it's ever been. The spurs that broke off years ago are pinching every time I land in the crater, reminding me of my age, telling me that the years have not been without cost and my body, with the adrenaline of a series no longer in front of me, starts to show its hurt.